

Syracuse - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | ACC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Low-end Power 4 / fringe-bowl quality with a defense-first path to improvement
Preseason consensus	AP unranked (0 votes) · ACC media 14th (878 points) · SP+ No. 76
Returning production	62% (No. 27) overall · Off. 56% (No. 62) · Def. 67% (No. 10)
Primer power rating	-2.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	4.3 wins · most likely 4-8
Net vs. 2025	● ↑ Better - Better, but still below average Power 4
Confidence	Medium

2026 identity: Syracuse stabilizes around QB Steve Angeli, a rebuilt run game and conservative protection while DC Vince Kehres leans on veteran LB/secondary continuity. The question is whether the new offensive groups and defensive front can support that spine.

Bottom line: Syracuse can improve on 3-9 because QB and defensive continuity are stronger, but WR, OL and defensive-front weakness still makes a clean bowl breakthrough unlikely.

Beats expectations if: QB Steve Angeli stays healthy, the new OL/RB group becomes functional, and the veteran back seven converts No. 10 defensive returning production into better efficiency.

Disappoints if: WR availability remains poor, the OL cannot protect QB Steve Angeli, and front-seven turnover prevents the defense from converting experience into efficiency.

Five things to remember

- 1 Quarterback:** QB Steve Angeli is the projected starter after returning from the Achilles injury that ended his 2025 season.
- 2 Receiver room:** The receiver room is the clearest offensive danger point: 2025 leaders WR Johntay Cook II and WR Darrell Gill Jr. transferred, WR Justus Ross-Simmons is currently ineligible, and WR Terrell Wilfong has a broken collarbone.
- 3 Secondary:** Defense returns 67% of production (No. 10), with LB Gary Bryant III, LB Antoine Deslauriers, CB Chris Peal, DB Demetres Samuel Jr., DB Braheem Long and DB Cornell Perry forming a much more experienced back-seven core than the rebuilt front.
- 4 ? Defensive availability:** Vince Kehres is the new DC and John Scott Jr. the new co-DC; the exact 2026 defensive primary game-day caller remains unresolved.
- 5 Schedule pressure:** SP+ is only No. 76 with 4.3 projected wins and SOS No. 47, so improvement from 3-9 is more defensible than assuming an immediate return to the ACC middle class.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	3-9 (1-7 ACC)	● Very poor
Scoring	20.2 PPG	● Poor
Total offense	340.4 YPG	● Poor
Rush offense	123.2 YPG · 3.4 YPC	● Poor
Pass efficiency	6.37 YPA · 17 TD / 15 INT	● Very poor
Third downs	35.3%	● Poor
Scoring defense	34.9 PPG allowed	● Very poor
Total defense	427.7 YPG allowed	● Very poor
Rush defense	174.9 YPG · 5.3 YPC	● Below average
Pass defense	252.8 YPG · 7.76 YPA · 23 TD allowed	● Poor

Both sides were clear weaknesses. Syracuse ranked No. 118 in scoring offense, No. 106 in total offense, No. 125 in pass efficiency and No. 106 on third downs; defensively it was No. 130 in scoring, No. 126 in total defense and No. 119 in pass-efficiency defense.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	-7.71 · No. 127	● Very poor
Off. EPA/play	-0.158 · No. 122	● Very poor
Off. success rate	38.8% · No. 111	● Poor
Off. explosive-play rate	11.0% · No. 99	● Below average
Havoc allowed	18.8% · No. 126	● Very poor
Opp.-adjusted defense	-6.09 · No. 118	● Poor
Def. EPA/play allowed	+0.090 · No. 106	● Poor
Def. success rate allowed	46.4% · No. 123	● Very poor
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	14.1% · No. 119	● Poor
Havoc created	14.2% · No. 97	● Below average

Advanced-stat read: The 2025 collapse was broad: Syracuse was bottom-tier in adjusted offense, EPA, pass efficiency, adjusted defense and defensive success rate while also allowing too much havoc and too many explosives. Improvement therefore depends on healthier QB play, roster changes and defensive continuity.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Fran Brown - returning	● ↔ Keeps the program direction stable while the roster turns over around him.
OC / RB	Jeff Nixon - returning; exact 2026 game-day play caller unresolved	● ↔ Offensive staff continuity helps, but unresolved game-day play-calling leaves one decision point open.
DC	◆ Vince Kehres - new from Toledo DC; exact primary game-day caller unresolved	● ↑ Kehres brings a new defensive structure, but primary game-day play-calling responsibility remains unsettled.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ RB Ahmad Miller	Jackson State	● ↔ 1,035-yard lower-level producer gives Syracuse a plausible lead back but does not erase the loss of RB Yasin Willis and Will Nixon.
◆ RB Ju'Juan Johnson	LSU	● ↔ Adds major-rotation athletic depth in an unsettled backfield.
◆ OL Oluwafunto Akinshilo	UCLA	● ↔ Projects into the starting five at guard, but the line remains a projection rather than a proven unit.
◆ TE Noah Meyers	Western Kentucky	● ↔ Expected meaningful receiving role after TE Dan Villari left for professional football.

Out	To	Loss
RB Yasin Willis	Kansas	● ↓ 2025 rushing leader leaves, forcing a new lead-back hierarchy.
WR Johntay Cook II	Ole Miss	● ↓ One of the top 2025 receivers exits an already-thin room.
WR Darrell Gill Jr.	Ole Miss	● ↓ Another leading 2025 receiver departs, magnifying current availability problems.
TE Dan Villari	NFL (L.A. Rams), undrafted free agent	● ↓ 39 catches for 412 yards leave the TE/inside receiving structure.
OL Da'Metrius Weatherspoon	NFL (Buffalo), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Material offensive-line contributor departs from a unit already rebuilding.

Offensive net: ● ↓ **Worse composition**, with QB health providing a separate path to better performance.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ DL Tunmise Adeleye	UNLV	● ↑ Named front leader and the most important incoming piece in a rebuilt defensive line.
◆ DL Dillan Fontus	Maryland	● ↔ Expected major role, but not yet a proven upgrade.
◆ LB Chris D'Appolonia	Toledo	● ↔ Adds competition and scheme familiarity around two high-volume returning linebackers.

Out	To	Loss
DL Kevin Jobity Jr.	NFL (Pittsburgh), undrafted free agent	● ↓ 30-tackle front contributor leaves.
DL Dion Wilson Jr.	NFL (Baltimore), undrafted free agent	● ↓ 29-tackle interior/front contributor leaves.
EDGE David Reese	NFL (L.A. Chargers), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Edge production exits during a front rebuild.
DL Denis Jaquez Jr.	Eligibility / graduation	● ↓ Ten starts, four TFL and two sacks depart via eligibility/graduation.
CB Duce Chestnut	Rookie-minicamp opportunity (San Francisco 49ers)	● ↓ A 48-tackle contributor leaves for a rookie-minicamp opportunity; no NFL roster role is established.

Defensive net: ● ↔ **Roughly similar**, with a lower front-seven floor and stronger returning back-seven base.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	QB-stability-first offense around QB Steve Angeli, a transfer RB rotation and rebuilt OL.	QB Angeli offers a clearer plan, with RB Ahmad Miller/RB Ju'Juan Johnson adding fresh options.	WR availability and OL continuity can force obvious passing downs.
Defense	DC Vince Kehres emphasizes assignment clarity and speed, with the strongest continuity at LB/secondary.	LB Gary Bryant III, LB Antoine Deslauriers, CB Chris Peal and DB Demetres Samuel Jr. form a veteran spine.	Rebuilt front after major departures and poor 2025 efficiency.
Special teams	Experienced returning kicker, new punter operation.	Tripp Woody made 12 of 14 field goals and SP+ special teams is No.35.	Punter is unresolved after Stonehouse departed, and kickoff specialist Jadyn Oh also transferred.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B-	● ↑	Medium	QB Steve Angeli returns from the Achilles injury and gives Syracuse a clearer starting plan.
RB	● C+	● ↔	Medium	RB Ahmad Miller brings 1,035-yard lower-level production to an unsettled new backfield.
WR	● C-	● ↓	Low	WR Umari Hatcher leads a room hit by major transfers plus current injury/eligibility absences.
TE	● C+	● ↓	Medium	TE Noah Meyers replaces NFL-bound TE Dan Villari in a thinner inside-receiving structure.
OL	● C	● ↔	Low	OL Oluwafunto Akinshilo projects into a rebuilt line with no settled high-end unit.
DL/Edge	● C+	● ↔	Medium-low	DL Tunmise Adeleye leads a rebuilt front replacing several veteran/professional departures.
LB	● B	● ↑	Medium-high	LB Gary Bryant III and LB Antoine Deslauriers provide rare returning volume and stability.
Secondary	● B	● ↑	Medium-high	CB Chris Peal and DB Demetres Samuel Jr. anchor the defense's most experienced unit.
Special teams	● B-	● ↔	Medium	Tripp Woody made 12 of 14 field goals and SP+ special teams is No.35.
Coaching	● B-	● ↔	Medium	HC Fran Brown and OC Jeff Nixon return while DC Vince Kehres changes the defense; primary caller remains unresolved.
Overall	● C+	● ↑	Medium	Low-end Power 4 / fringe-bowl quality with a defense-first path to improvement

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Steve Angeli	QB	● Solid Power 4 starter projection / health return	-	Projected QB1 after returning from the Achilles injury that ended his 2025 season; Syracuse needs his stability to raise a bottom-tier passing-efficiency baseline.
Chris Peal	CB	● High-end conference starter	ACC first team · Jim Thorpe Award watchlist	First-team ACC corner and central anchor of the experienced secondary.
Gary Bryant III	LB	● High-volume conference starter	Butkus Award watchlist	Returns after 60 tackles and forms the linebacker core with LB Antoine Deslauriers.
Demetres Samuel Jr.	DB	● High-upside secondary/return weapon	Paul Hornung Award watchlist	Returns after 45 tackles and gives the secondary another major-role athlete.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
♦ Tunmise Adeleye (TR: UNLV)	DL	● Projected front-line leader	-	UNLV transfer is explicitly identified in camp as a leader of a rebuilt defensive front.
♦ Ahmad Miller (TR: Jackson State)	RB	● Lead-back projection with lower-level production	-	Arrives after a 1,035-yard Jackson State season and has the strongest current lead-role case.
Umari Hatcher	WR	● Featured receiver projection	-	The clearest expected starting receiver after transfer losses and current injuries/eligibility issues reshaped the room.
Antoine Deslauriers	LB	● Reliable high-volume returning starter	-	Returns after 60 tackles and helps make linebacker one of Syracuse's most stable units.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Manageable enough to improve, but too many games against clearly better ACC opponents for a low-error roster
Difficulty	● 6/10 · Moderate · SP+ SOS No. 47
Hardest stretch	Louisville → at North Carolina → SMU → Clemson
Swing games	California, at UConn, at North Carolina, at Boston College
Advantage	The opener is FCS New Hampshire, the only bye comes before the road UConn game, and several mid-tier opponents are separated from the Notre Dame finale.
Expected	4.3 wins · most likely 4-8
Floor / ceiling	2-10 / 7-5

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	A 3-9 record and zero AP votes limit premium pricing, while No. 10 defensive returning production and QB Steve Angeli's return create selective underdog appeal.
Back them when	Catching points against average offenses once QB Steve Angeli is healthy and the veteran LB/secondary core is intact.
Fade/pass when	Laying points or facing clear front-seven advantages before the rebuilt OL and thin WR rotation prove functional.
Key monitor	QB Steve Angeli health/form, WR Justus Ross-Simmons eligibility, WR Terrell Wilfong return, final OL five, RB touches
Week 1 baseline	vs. New Hampshire: no independent preseason fair line; use the live market as the opening benchmark. Live market: Syracuse -32.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Syracuse has a credible improvement path because QB Steve Angeli returns and the defense brings back a veteran LB/secondary core. The 2025 baseline was poor on both sides, however, and the WR room, OL and defensive front are all being rebuilt.

Four wins remains the likeliest result, and the record could undersell real improvement. Bowl upside requires QB health, functional protection and a meaningful defensive efficiency jump; otherwise the schedule contains too many clearly stronger ACC opponents.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [camp update](#) · [roster roles](#) · [coaching](#) · [current update](#) · [current update 2](#) · [current update 3](#)

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